



EUROPEAN UNION

“Europe Can Be Liked”

1. Basic Information

Workshop title:

Regional Policy and EU Funds

Scenario author:

Nora Šnepste

Duration:

Approximately 2–2.5 teaching hours (120–150 minutes)

Number of participants:

12–25 people

2. Workshop Objectives

General objectives:

- To develop understanding of the European Union’s regional policy and EU funds
- To develop the ability to view EU issues from different perspectives
- To encourage reflection on directions of European regional development

Specific objectives:

- To understand that the European Union is a process of negotiation, compromise, and choices
- To become familiar with different perspectives (Member State, candidate country)
- To develop argumentation and opinion-forming skills
- To strengthen empathy and dialogue skills

3. Target Group Description

The workshop is intended for adults, especially seniors, who are interested in the European Union, its regional policy, and EU funding opportunities. No prior knowledge is



required – participants’ life experience and willingness to engage in the proposed methods and activities are essential.

4. Working Methods

- “Living Library” method – people become “books” that can be “read” through conversation
- Moderated discussion
- Group work
- Brainstorming
- Interactive lecture elements

5. Materials and Resources

- Computers for information search and tests
- Paper sheets and pens
- Whiteboard or flipchart paper
- Markers
- Clock or timer
- Materials for writing recommendations to EU policymakers

6. Workshop / Session Structure

1. Introduction

- Welcome of participants
- Presentation of workshop goals and rules (respect, no “right” or “wrong” answers, right to change one’s opinion)
- Short introduction/overview of methods and activities used in the session



Main Part — Educational Activities

Activity 1: “What I Know About the European Union”

Goal:

- To engage participants
- To use personal experience related to the EU

Description:

Participants work in pairs and share memories and reflections about the European Union.

Instructions:

The facilitator asks participants to work in pairs and discuss:

- When did I first hear about the European Union?
- What do I know about EU regional policy and EU funds?
- How has the European Union and its opportunities changed my life?

After pair work, those who wish briefly share their conclusions with the group.

Time: 15 minutes

Materials: Not required

Activity 2: Interactive Lecture / Presentation

Goals:

- To introduce participants to EU regional policy directions and EU funds, and their opportunities for different groups in society
- To explore different perspectives, limitations, and risks
- To develop argumentation skills

Description:

The moderator presents EU regional policy priorities and available EU funds allocated to each Member State, as well as funded projects in Municipality.

Presentation outline:



1. Principles and values

https://european-union.europa.eu/principles-countries-history/principles-and-values_lv

2. Main achievements of the European Union and benefits for citizens

The EU has achieved many things for its citizens and the world:

- Citizens have the right to live, study, and work anywhere in the EU
- Prosperity through the world's largest single market and a common currency
- Growth through the world's largest trading bloc
- Protection of fundamental, digital, social, and economic rights
- Visa-free travel through the Schengen Area
- Leadership in climate action, environmental protection, and sustainable energy
- Protection of health and food safety standards
- Solidarity in times of natural disasters, economic crises, or pandemics
- Over 70 years of peace and stability
- Enlargement and increasing unity of the EU
- Humanitarian and development assistance worldwide

3. EU regional policy

EU regional policy is the main investment policy of the European Union. It supports job creation, competitiveness, economic growth, quality of life, and sustainable development, ensuring that no region is left behind.

Short discussion: dreams vs reality / advantages vs disadvantages / benefits vs limitations

For 2021–2027, €392 billion is allocated to cohesion policy, nearly one-third of the EU budget.

Main funds:

https://ec.europa.eu/regional_policy/policy/what_en

- European Regional Development Fund (ERDF) – invests in social and economic development of all EU regions and cities



- Cohesion Fund (CF) – supports environment and transport in less prosperous EU countries
- European Social Fund Plus (ESF+) – supports jobs and social inclusion
- Just Transition Fund (JTF) – supports regions most affected by the transition to climate neutrality

Cohesion policy supports:

- Education
- Employment
- Energy
- Environment
- Single market
- Research and innovation

Key EU priorities:

- “European Green Deal”
- “A Europe fit for the Digital Age”
- “An economy that works for people”

Territorial dimension:

- Border regions and cross-border cooperation (Interreg)
- Urban areas
- Remote, island, mountainous, or sparsely populated regions
- Outermost regions

Cohesion policy and solidarity:

- Focus on less developed regions to reduce disparities
- Just Transition Fund supports adaptation to climate transition
- REACT-EU supports recovery after COVID-19

Legislation:



- Articles 174–178 of the Treaty on the Functioning of the EU

Myth-busting:

https://ec.europa.eu/regional_policy/policy/what/myth-busting_en

4. What Europe does for me

<https://what-europe-does-for-me.europarl.europa.eu/en/home>

In my region:

<https://what-europe-does-for-me.europarl.europa.eu/en/region?area=LV&txt=Latvija>

5. Structural and investment funds supporting regional development:

- Cohesion Fund projects in Latgale

<https://kohesio.ec.europa.eu/en/beneficiaries?country=Latvia®ion=Latgale>

EU test “My Europe. My Future.”

<https://manaeiropa.esmaja.lv/>

Discussion topics: problems in distribution and absorption of EU funds (old vs new Member States, bureaucracy at EU and local levels, etc.)

Activity 3: Discussion and Reflection

Goals:

- To deepen reflection
- To develop understanding of challenges in EU fund distribution and absorption across Member States, Latvia, regions, and Latgale

Description:

Group discussion after the session.

Instructions:

The facilitator asks:

- Did I gain new information / expand my knowledge / deepen my understanding?
- Can and should the European Union satisfy everyone?

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Flipchart



3. Conclusion and Reflection

In groups (or jointly), participants prepare and write “Senior Recommendations for Improving EU Regional Policy and Fairer Distribution and Absorption of EU Funds”, taking into account regional development needs.

Final output: a document summarize participants’ key conclusions, values, and recommendations (1–2 pages).

Time: 30 minutes

7. Evaluation of the Session

- Short final discussion
- Evaluation questions (e.g., what was most valuable, what surprised participants)
- Optional anonymous short survey

8. Recommendations

- Continue sessions as a series of meetings
- Explore individual topics in more depth (migration, EU enlargement, regional inequality)
- Organize similar workshops for different age groups